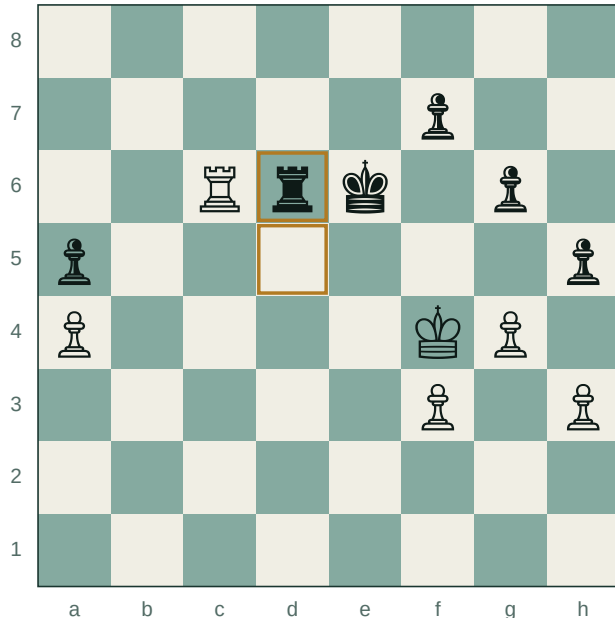


# Rook-ending tactics: White, move 38

Rook-ending tactics

White to move



Previous move: 37...Rd6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

**WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST**

**38. Rxd6+ Kxd6 39. gxh5**

**38.Rxd6+** Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. The move also takes the rook on d6. Recorded reply: **38...Kxd6**.

**39.gxh5** The pawn captures the pawn on h5.

At the end, nominal material is White 4 / Black 3 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

**CHECKPOINT**

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +1: the balance goes from +0 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

**CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES**

A routine rook placement can miss a skewer or promotion with check. Let concrete tactics override a guideline when they conflict.

**WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES**

Rook endings combine pawn races with checks, cutoffs, and promotion tactics. Activity is vital, but the exact move order often decides whether a pawn can advance safely.

**HOW TO LOOK**

Check the kings' exposure, the rooks' checking distance, and the passed pawns. Calculate forcing checks before applying a general rook-ending rule.

The defending king is on e6. Absolute pin: rook on d6.